

ACCURATE PUNCTUATION

Using punctuation correctly and purposefully



1 What is it?

Accurate Punctuation

Accurate punctuation means using **commas, full stops, semicolons and more** correctly — not just to follow rules, but to control meaning, pace and clarity.

correct punctuation = clear meaning

2 See it in action

A comma changes meaning

"Let's eat, Grandma" vs. "Let's eat Grandma" — punctuation can change the whole sentence.

A semicolon

She loved the sea; it reminded her of home. Joins two related ideas.

A dash for emphasis

There was only one thing left to do — run.

A colon to introduce

He had one rule: never look back.



Good spot!

If you're only ever using **commas and full stops**, try adding one semicolon, one colon, and one dash into your next piece for variety and control.

FUN FACT

The classic example "Let's eat, Grandma" vs. "Let's eat Grandma" is famous for a reason — it's one of the clearest possible demonstrations that punctuation isn't just decoration, it genuinely changes meaning.

3 Why writers use it

Accurate Punctuation helps writers: make meaning clear and unambiguous for the reader, control pace and emphasis within a sentence, and demonstrate technical control over writing, which examiners specifically reward.

Beyond correctness, punctuation is a genuine stylistic tool — a well-placed dash or colon can create emphasis and drama in exactly the same way a carefully chosen word can.

4 Where you'll spot it

Exam mark schemes

Accurate and **VARIED** punctuation (not just full stops and commas) is explicitly rewarded at the top grade bands.

Professional editing

A misplaced comma can completely change a sentence's meaning, which is why editors treat punctuation as a meaning-making tool, not just decoration.



Watch out!

Don't add commas just because a sentence "feels long" — a comma should mark a genuine pause, list, or clause boundary, not just appear at a random point.



Keep going!

Read a sentence aloud and notice where you **naturally pause** — that's usually where a comma, dash, or full stop belongs.

5 Quick recap

Controls meaning, pace, clarity

More than just following rules

Variety (dashes, colons) impresses examiners



Mfalme says...

Try writing the same short sentence three ways — using a comma, then a dash, then a colon — and notice how the pace and emphasis shifts each time.